

7-Papers Assignment, Cover Page

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Paper title: The Rise of Distinctively Ugly Luxury: Challenging Aesthetics in Fashion

The Rise of Distinctively Ugly Luxury: Challenging Aesthetics in Fashion

The concept of luxury has been evolved significantly in recent years, especially evident in the rise of “ugly luxury,” where products challenge traditional standard of beauty and attractiveness (Cesareo, Townsend, and Shi, 2019). Despite its unconventional aesthetic, this trend has gained popularity among consumers. This overview explores the current state of research on this phenomenon, drawing insights from seven papers that examine the intersections of fashion, consumer behavior, and the acceptance of ugliness in luxury items.

Aesthetic Values

Taking a hermeneutic approach, Rhodes (2010) interprets the meaning of ugliness in fashion. This thesis introduces the idea that fashion can incorporate elements traditionally viewed as undesirable, such as holes, stains, and tears to create a new mode of expression (including designs by Vivienne Westwood, Martin Margiela, and Rei Kawakubo). The analysis also draws on theories from philosophers, sociologists, and fashion scholars to contextualize the trend. By questioning the dominance of beauty and glamor, Rhodes sets the stage for understanding how ugly luxury products can reshape consumer perceptions of attractiveness.

Building on this, Choat (2015) discusses the ugly / beautiful paradigm, and explains that the definitions of “beauty” and “ugly” are socially constructed and fluid, rather than wholly defined by the object or mind. Designers now draw on artistic complexities that challenge established knowledge. Fashion consumption is not just about seeking beauty, but is instead a complex ideological system that allows consumers to engage with conflicting and contrasting aesthetic meanings. The study argues that contemporary fashion embraces ugliness as a legitimate aesthetic and this perspective contributes to the acceptance of ugly luxury in the market.

Consumer Motivations

Further examining consumer behavior, Chan, To, and Chu (2015) investigate the motivations driving materialistic consumers to seek unique luxury products by collecting data through 568 sampling luxury goods shoppers in Hong Kong. Their findings reveal that affective response had the strongest direct impact on repurchase intention, as well as the need for uniqueness and materialism had indirect effects on repurchase intention through status consumption. It suggests that individuals seeking for distinctiveness are more likely to choose ugly luxury products, viewing them as symbols of status that set them apart from the mainstream.

Cesareo, Townsend, and Shi (2019) also address that distinctiveness, in the form of deliberate ugliness, can provide valuable benefits in the luxury context. They conducted five studies

including using real sales data from Amazon to compare consumer choices for attractive vs. ugly products in luxury vs. non-luxury contexts; doing experiments where participants evaluated and chose between attractive and unattractive products described as either luxury or non-luxury brands. They found distinctively ugly luxury products were seen as more likely to be from a luxury brand and more fashion one compared to attractive luxury products. Their findings showcase that context can shape preferences and that luxury consumers may value distinctiveness over attractiveness.

Acceptance of Ugliness

Thomas and Abraham (2022) did further exploration of motivations behind the acceptance of ugly fashion trends. They conducted a discourse analysis of 70 articles published between 2017 and 2021 on fashion, entertainment, lifestyle, and news websites. These articles included perspectives from consumers, journalists, fashion experts, celebrities, and social influencers. The analysis revealed four main factors that drive the acceptance of ugly fashion trends: collective action; eyes of the beholder; herd behavior or the bandwagon effect; abnormal becomes the social norm.

Through 32 interviews with upper-middle-class consumers, Zanette, Pueschel, and Touzani (2022) discovers that though at first consumers have issue with ugly luxury because they don't match the idea of good taste, they will gradually adapt and incorporate these items into their dressing routine, and eventually change their perception of good taste over time. This research shows that objects, competencies, and meanings evolve together.

The most recent study by Cesareo, Townsend, and Pavlov (2023) offers a comprehensive examination of why consumers are willing to purchase distinctively ugly luxury products. The researchers conducted a field study on Instagram examining actual consumer behavior (click-through-rates), finding out while consumers avoid ugly products from non-luxury brands, they choose distinctively ugly luxury products no less than the attractive ones. However, through controlled laboratory experiments and a computer vision-based model, the researchers show that when a loud luxury logo is present, the distinctively ugly aesthetic no longer provides additional signaling value. This study provides guidance on how to effectively leverage distinctive ugliness and branding elements to appeal to consumers.

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